

Target Audience Research

September 2026

Summary

Apex sells to people who built something real and are now trapped inside it. Both audiences share one core condition: they are the single point of contact, every thread runs through them, and the tools meant to help (including AI) have become more trail to navigate, not less.

Primary: the AI-aware small business owner. An owner-operator in the Dan Martell orbit who has read or watched Buy Back Your Time, knows AI matters, has tried ChatGPT or Claude, and still spends the week answering email, chasing follow-ups and holding context no one else has. They want to become the owner who leads the business instead of running it.

Secondary: the content creator building a personal brand. A solo or small-team creator whose brand is the business. They are the talent, the editor, the inbox, the sales team and the accountant. They want to become the creator who creates, with the business running quietly behind them.

The shift Apex sells: from the Overwhelmed Explorer lost in the forest (single point of failure, reactive, noise everywhere) to the Conquering Hero at the summit (clear view, time owned, peace of mind). Evidence for each claim follows, and every line marked inference is a judgment call to validate with customer data.

Brand strategy (locked)

Apex is the guide that takes AI-aware owners and creators out of the forest of doing everything themselves and up to the summit, where the business runs without them and they get their freedom and peace of mind back.

- The customer is the hero who conquers the mountain. Apex sells that identity.
- Apex is the Sherpa. It guides; it never takes the summit photo.
- Dan Martell is visible, but the brand must stand on its own without him.

Context: Apex today and the Martell ecosystem

Apex launches into an audience that already believes the core promise: time is the asset, and freedom comes from buying it back. Apex's job is to make that belief feel achievable with AI, without the owner becoming an AI engineer.

What apex.host says today

Claim	Where it appears
"One memory across everything you use." Your business memory: "the people, companies, meetings, deals and commitments in your world"	apex.host
"Nothing to file, tag or tidy" / "It does the thing" / "It carries between models" / "It shows its receipts"	apex.host
"Businesses over \$400K get a call straight after" joining the waitlist	apex.host
"Your digital twin: an AI that doesn't just chat, it does the work"; built as Dan's personal digital twin, aimed at "founders managing multiple businesses"	What is Apex
Self-hosted, "100% IP ownership", works with "the AI models you choose to use"	FAQ
Launched March 29, 2026. Dan: "You don't add AI to your business. You rebuild the business with AI as the foundation."	Press release

The current voice is product-first and technical (agents, memory, integrations, self-hosting). It describes what Apex does. It does not yet describe who the customer becomes. That gap is the repositioning opportunity.

Dan Martell's audience at a glance

Signal	Figure	Source
YouTube subscribers	3.08M (Sept 2026), 4.15% engagement	HypeAuditor
Stated reach	"12M+ entrepreneurs"	danmartell.com
Combined YouTube + Instagram	6.2M followers	CreatorDB
Flagship idea	Buy Back Your Time, a WSJ bestseller	About Dan
Content categories	Entrepreneurship, startups, personal development, leadership, sales	HypeAuditor

The vocabulary this audience already speaks

Martell's audience has been trained in a specific language of freedom. Apex should speak it fluently, not reinvent it.

- **Buyback Loop (Audit, Transfer, Fill):** audit draining work, hand it off, refill the time with high-value work ([summary](#)).
- **Replacement Ladder:** the order in which an owner hands off roles, starting with admin, climbing toward leadership. The book frames the top rung as becoming an "empire builder" ([buybackyourtime.com](#)).
- **Perfect Week, Buyback Rate, 95/5 Rule, Definition of Done:** tools for designing a life around chosen work ([buybackyourtime.com](#)).
- **Time Assassins:** inbox checking, excess meetings, undocumented processes ([summary](#)).
- **The pain he names:** "Failed businesses. 100 hour weeks. Burnout." and the goal to "systemize and reclaim freedom" ([danmartell.com](#)); "Are you tired of feeling overwhelmed and putting out fires in your business?" ([buybackyourtime.com](#)).

Inference: Apex is the Replacement Ladder with a new first rung. For owners who cannot yet afford an EA, Apex is the first hire.

Audience landscape: testing primary and secondary

The primary holds. The secondary holds only if it is narrowed from "content creators" to creators who run a business behind their brand. Ten candidate audiences were scored on the five things Apex needs: the single-point-of-contact pain, AI readiness, ability to pay \$10K a year, reach through the Martell audience, and fit with the forest-to-summit identity.

Audience	Who they are	Pain fit	AI readiness	Pays \$10K/yr	Martell reach	Verdict
Small business owner-operators	Service, agency, trades, SaaS owners around \$400K to a few million in revenue	High: 82% lose sleep, ~30% of week on documents (Adobe)	Medium to high: 58% use gen AI (U.S. Chamber)	Yes above ~\$400K	Core Martell audience	PRIMARY. Confirmed
Personal-brand creators with a business	Creators who monetize through coaching, courses, community or services	High: 52% burnout (Billion Dollar Boy)	Medium: fear of sounding generic	Yes, if revenue is steady	Strong: Dan is their model	SECONDARY. Confirmed, narrowed
Pure content creators	Income from ads and brand deals only	High	Medium	Weak: 55% of burnt-out creators cite financial instability (Billion Dollar Boy)	Medium	Not a fit at \$10K
Multi-business founders	Operators running two or more companies	Very high	High	Easily	High: Apex docs name them directly (What is Apex)	Flagship subset of primary
SaaS and software founders	Dan's historic base: 3,000+ founders coached through SaaS Academy (Precision)	High	Very high	Yes	Very high	Subset of primary. Note: SaaS Academy now powers Precision's AI agents, an adjacent offer
Agency owners	Marketing and creative agencies, 84% under 25 people (SparkToro)	High: client comms land on the owner	High, but 53% see AI as a threat	Yes	Medium	Subset of primary
Coaches and consultants	122,974 coaches worldwide (ICF)	High	Low: only 19% invested in AI last year	Top earners only	High	Folds into secondary

Audience	Who they are	Pain fit	AI readiness	Pays \$10K/yr	Martell reach	Verdict
Relationship professionals	Real estate agents, brokers, advisors	High: follow-up heavy	Medium: 48% use AI daily or weekly; 63% cite learning curve (NAR, Sept 2026)	Top producers	Low	Future vertical
Mid-market CEOs and executives	Leaders of \$5M+ companies; 62.5 hours a week, 3 to 4 hours of email a day (Stealth Agents)	Medium: often have an EA	High	Easily	Medium: Dan's inner circles	Upmarket expansion
Solopreneurs and freelancers	29.8M U.S. nonemployer businesses (Census)	High	Mixed	No	High	Not a fit at \$10K
Technical self-hosters	OpenClaw users; 247,000 GitHub stars by March 2026 (Wikipedia)	Low: they enjoy the build	Very high	Rarely	Low	Early adopters and advocates, not buyers

What the test shows. The owner-operator is the right primary: highest pain, can pay, and already speaks Martell's language. Multi-business founders, SaaS founders and agency owners are not separate audiences; they are the sharpest slices of the primary and make the best early case studies. The secondary is right in spirit but needs a tighter definition: the creator whose brand funds a real business. Pure ad-revenue creators and solopreneurs share the pain but not the budget.

Primary persona: the AI-aware small business owner

They built a business that works because they work. They know AI is the way out and have tried it, but every new tool is one more thing they have to manage.

Snapshot

Attribute	Profile	Basis
Role	Owner-operator, founder or CEO of a service, agency, coaching, trades or SaaS business	Martell audience + Apex docs
Size	Roughly \$400K to a few million in revenue, small team or contractors	Apex call threshold (apex.host); upper bound is inference
Stage	Past survival, stuck before scale. Revenue is real, leverage is not	Inference from Replacement Ladder framing

Attribute	Profile	Basis
AI posture	Uses ChatGPT or Claude weekly; has no system; unsure what to trust	See AI evidence below
Willingness to pay	Can justify \$10K/year if it replaces hours or a hire	Apex pricing brief; Buyback Rate logic
Where they are	YouTube, podcasts, Martell newsletter, masterminds, LinkedIn, X	Martell channel data

What they struggle with

Struggle	Evidence
They are the bottleneck. Every decision, reply and follow-up needs them	Martell names "100 hour weeks" and "putting out fires" as the defining pain (danmartell.com , buybackyourtime.com)
Admin crushes strategy	Entrepreneurs spend ~30% of the week on document management; nearly half feel burnt out by admin (Adobe , 1,018 owners, 2025)
They never switch off	82% lose sleep over work; average 11 days off a year (Adobe); 53.5% lose sleep a few times a week or more (Patriot Software , 1,000 owners, May 2026)
The business costs them their life	84.4% have sacrificed health, relationships or wellbeing; 45.8% sacrificed family time (Patriot Software)
AI feels urgent but scattered	58% of small businesses use generative AI, up from 40% in 2024 (U.S. Chamber , Aug 2025), but only an estimated 15 to 20% use it strategically and 77% have no AI policy (Digital Applied)
The wider market is confused	Among all small owners, 62% cite lack of understanding of AI's benefits and 55% cite cost (NEXT , 1,500 owners, Apr 2025)

The last two rows matter together. The broad small business market is split and skeptical. The Martell subset is the aware minority: sold on AI, stuck on implementation. That is the forest. They can see the trees (tools) but not the path.

What they want to become

- **The owner who leads, not the operator who runs.** Martell's top rung is the "empire builder" who designs a Perfect Week (buybackyourtime.com).
- **Present at home.** Family time is the most-cited sacrifice ([Patriot Software](#)). Inference: "peace of mind" here means being fully present at dinner without a phone buzzing.
- **Ahead, not catching up.** They want to be the owner other owners ask about AI, not the one still reading threads about it. Inference from Martell's AI-first content and Apex's "rebuild the business with AI as the foundation" message.

What they believe

- Time is worth more than money, and you buy it back before you think you can afford to (Buyback Rate).
- Systems beat hustle. Hustle got them here; it will not get them further.
- AI is a leverage shift on the scale of the internet. Being late is expensive.
- Inference: they distrust hype, lock-in and tools that need babysitting. Apex's "carries between models" and "shows its receipts" claims ([apex.host](#)) answer this directly.

Dreams

Inference, to validate with customer interviews: a business that runs a week without them; a real vacation; more time for health and kids; building a second company or investing; being seen as a leader rather than the busiest person in the room.

Likely objections

- "I've tried AI tools. They create more work."
- "Will this see things it shouldn't?" (answered by self-hosting and IP ownership, [FAQ](#))
- "What happens when a better model comes out?" (answered by model portability)
- "\$10K is a lot for software." (reframe against an EA salary and the Buyback Rate)

Secondary persona: the content creator

Their face is the brand and their inbox is the business. They started to create and now spend most of their energy managing everything around the creating.

Snapshot

Attribute	Profile	Basis
Role	Personal-brand creator: educator, coach, niche YouTuber, podcaster, LinkedIn or X operator	Apex brief
Business model	Brand deals, courses, coaching, community, digital products	Inference, typical Martell-adjacent creator
Team	Solo or one to three helpers (editor, VA)	Inference
AI posture	Uses AI for scripts, captions, repurposing; nothing connects	Inference
Why Martell	Dan is the model: an operator who became a media company (3.08M subscribers)	HypeAuditor

What they struggle with

Struggle	Evidence
Burnout is the norm	52% of creators have experienced burnout; 37% are considering leaving (Billion Dollar Boy , 1,000 creators, Jul 2025)
Creative fatigue and workload	Top triggers: creative fatigue 40%, demanding workloads 31%, constant screen time 27% (Billion Dollar Boy)
Income instability	55% of burnt-out creators name financial instability as the biggest factor (Billion Dollar Boy)
Isolation and metric obsession	Stressors include income uncertainty, obsession with performance metrics, constant work demands and "professional isolation" (Harvard Chan / C4MH , Nov 2025)
Algorithm pressure	U.S. creators struggle most with "navigating platform algorithm demands" (Billion Dollar Boy)

Inference: the creator's forest is louder than the owner's. It is DMs, sponsor threads, collaborator follow-ups, comment moderation and analytics, all landing on one person who is also expected to be on camera and energised.

What they want to become

- **The artist again.** Back to the work that made them love this.
- **A media company, not a job.** Dan himself is the template: a business mind with a content engine behind him.

- **Sustainable.** Burnout and quit-intent data show the dream is simply to still be doing this in five years.

What they believe

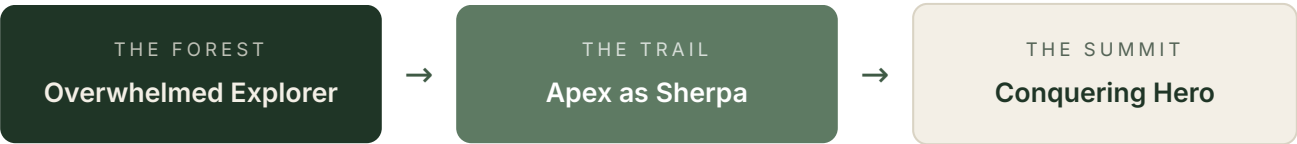
- Their personal brand is their most valuable asset and must stay authentically theirs.
- Consistency wins; missing a week feels like falling behind.
- Inference: they are wary of AI that makes them sound generic. Apex has to protect voice, not replace it.

How they differ from the primary

	Small business owner	Creator
Core fear	The business stalls without them	The audience forgets them
Relationship to AI	Leverage and systems	Speed, but a threat to authenticity
What freedom means	Time back, family, leadership	Creative energy, sustainability
Proof they want	ROI, hours saved, hire avoided	Output kept up, burnout avoided, voice intact

Archetypes: current vs transformational identity

Both audiences start as the Overwhelmed Explorer: they set out for freedom and got lost in the forest. Apex guides them to become the Conquering Hero, the one who reached the summit and earned their freedom.



The customer is always the hiker. Apex is never the hero; it is the guide who knows the route.

	Current identity	Current archetype	Transformational identity	Transformational archetype	Evidence for the shift
Small business owner	The one everything runs through; firefighter; the bottleneck	Ruler in shadow (control as burden) + Caregiver in shadow (Martyr): carries the team, the clients and the inbox	The owner who sees the whole mountain and chooses where to climb next	Hero (conquered the mountain, earned freedom) with a healthy Ruler (sovereign over time, not tasks)	"Systemize and reclaim freedom" (danmartell.com); 84.4% sacrificed health, family or wellbeing (Patriot)
Creator	Content machine; always on; performing for the algorithm	Creator in shadow (burnt-out Artist) + Performer	The artist with a quiet engine behind them; creates from overflow, not obligation	Hero (conquered the grind) with a restored Creator	52% burnout, 40% creative fatigue (Billion Dollar Boy)
Apex (brand role)	A technical AI agent product: digital twin, self-hosted, integrations. Describes what it does, not who you become	Magician as tool (feature-led, product as the hero)	The Sherpa: the guide who knows the route and gets the hiker to the summit. Never the hero	Sage as Guide (Sherpa); Magician secondary (AI that "does the thing")	"It shows its receipts" and "It does the thing" (apex.host); Dan built it as his own digital twin (docs)

Why Overwhelmed Explorer to Conquering Hero

- The Explorer's core desire in Mark & Pearson is freedom; its fear is being trapped. That is exactly where the audience starts: they went out for freedom and got stuck in the forest.
- The Hero's core desire is to prove worth through courageous action and mastery. The summit is earned, not handed over, which is why Apex is the Sherpa and never the hero.
- Martell's own story is this arc: from jail at 17 to three software exits ([About Dan](#)).
- Visual mood maps to the story: dark green tinted imagery for the forest and the climb, bright airy summit imagery for freedom.

Media diet: what they listen to and what they tune out

They listen to operators who have done it and tune out anyone selling a shortcut. This section is mostly inference from Martell's content categories ([HypeAuditor](#)) and should be checked against Apex waitlist data or a short survey.

	Tune in	Tune out
Voices	Dan Martell, Alex and Leila Hormozi, Codie Sanchez, Steven Bartlett, Tim Ferriss, operator-founders on X	Get-rich-quick gurus, faceless AI hype accounts, corporate thought leadership
Formats	Long-form YouTube, podcasts on the drive or at the gym, short frameworks on LinkedIn and X, masterminds	Webinars with a 40-minute pitch, whitepapers, dense technical docs
Messages	Frameworks with names, specific numbers, before-and-after stories, "here's my exact system"	"Revolutionary", "10x overnight", vague AI futurism, jargon (agents, orchestration, RAG) without outcomes
Proof	Founder stories, screenshots, hours saved, a peer they respect using it	Logos wall, feature grids, benchmarks
Tone	Direct, confident, calm, a little rugged	Cute, overexcited, apologetic

Inference for the brand: the current apex.host copy leans on the "tune out" vocabulary (agents, orchestration, self-hosting). The transformation language (summit, freedom, peace of mind) belongs up front, with the technical proof one layer down.

Sources

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